



Haryana's Deeya Yadav — both just 16 years old — also found 'market' interest.

But the biggest redemption arc was reserved for veteran Indian pacer Shikha Pandey. Puppeteered in and out of the national setup, the 36-year-old never abandoned the grind, putting in the hard yards in the domestic scene and in franchise leagues around the world.

"It is nice to know I am valued," she told every media house flooding her phone with calls. The story is similar for Arundhati Reddy, who, despite being one of the best in the domestic scene and producing heartening performances against Australia late last year, found herself relegated to the bench.

Asha Sobhana (**above, left**) — who drew ₹1.30 crore from the Warriorz — had struggled with the physical and mental toll of injury, which saw her miss the entire 2025 season. As the 34-year-old stacked up runs and wickets for Kerala, she

Unsold: Australian keeper-batter Alyssa Healy's recent injury frequency may have gone against her in the auction. She last played for UP Warriorz in the 2024 edition.

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had the backing of her old franchise RCB and eventually the monetary faith of a new team to keep her going.

The assurances are not just internal. A World Cup victory means more eyeballs for the sport; ergo, more commercial interest. Hours before the auction began, the BCCI announced the onboarding of three new sponsors until 2027 — ChatGPT, Bisleri, and Kingfisher — for a cumulative sum of ₹48 crore. With existing franchise owners predicting, and even welcoming, the idea of more teams entering the fray, the only way for the WPL — and the players who make it the competitive force it is — is upwards.

2026 auction trivia



- RCB was the only franchise not to spend a crore or more for a player
- Only three Indians drew a price tag of a crore or more this time; all three are primary bowlers
- UP Warriorz reassembled its core using the Right to Match option (featuring in the WPL for the first time), bringing four players back with the tool — Deepti Sharma, Sophie Ecclestone, Kiran Navgire and Kranti Gaud
- Uma Chetry is the only member of the victorious ODI World Cup-winning side who did not find a team in WPL 2026